

Report Part Title: The Military Planning Cycle:

Report Title: Europe Rediscovered Peacekeeping?

Report Subtitle: Political and Military Logics in the 2006 UNIFIL Enhancement

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Egmont Institute (2009)

Stable URL: <http://www.jstor.com/stable/resrep06671.7>

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The Military Planning Cycle: From Political Guidance to Operational Plans

As any organisation tasked with commanding armed forces, the UN has developed its own approach to the planning and conduct of peacekeeping operations. How UN peacekeeping should ‘work’ has been the subject of a decade-long series of reforms. Most notable in this regard were the publication of the guidelines for the UN Integrated Mission Planning Process (IMPP) and the Capstone Doctrine codifying the principles and guidelines for peacekeeping.¹⁵ The IMPP especially gives a clear outline of what the UN planning process should look like, if time and resources would allow it, that is. However, as UNIFIL does not qualify as an ‘integrated,’ multidimensional operation, and was planned under great time pressure, the planning cycle was far more ad hoc than what these doctrinal publications may suggest.

The hard core of planning documents that is key to any UN operation is the Concept of Operations (CONOPS), accompanied by a list of Force Requirements and a set of Rules of Engagement (ROE). The CONOPS is a concise sketch of the planned operation, which in the case of the UN mostly boils down to a phased deployment plan. The Force Requirements detail the wish list of what are the desired capabilities for the mission. The ROE, finally, describe in detail the conditions in which force can be used, and who has the authority to decide on this. The essence of these documents is processed into a report of the Secretary-general to the Security Council. What is important to bear in mind is that these documents, contrary to equivalent NATO or EU procedures, are internal DPKO documents that do *not* require the formal approval of the Security Council. Of course, the members of the Security Council and the troop contributing countries are kept informed of their content and can make suggestions during the drafting phase, albeit at a lower level of political ownership. In the summer of 2006, the DPKO authorities produced these initial planning documents in a time span of only days. Later on these would be fine-tuned by the SMC team, while more detailed operational-level planning started as a parallel process. On a conceptual level, however, UN doctrine is notoriously light on how to design operations in substantive terms. As a consequence, the main troop contributors for the enhanced UNIFIL – the Europeans – imported key elements of NATO planning doctrine, such as centre of gravity analysis, lines of operation etc.

15. *Integrated Missions Planning Process (IMPP): Guidelines Endorsed by the Secretary-General on 13 June 2006*, New York: United Nations Secretariat; *United Nations Peacekeeping Operations: Principles and Guidelines*. New York: UN Department of Peacekeeping Operations, 18 January 2008.

In this overview of how military planners conducted their mission analysis, operational design and concept development, we need to distinguish between, on the one hand, the transition planning for the UNIFIL enhancement itself and, on the other hand, the planning for how the enhanced UNIFIL would fulfil its mandate once it would be deployed. As far as the transition planning is concerned, the two key elements were the boosting of UNIFIL's numerical strength and capabilities, and the expansion of the area of operations to include the 'pocket' around the city of Tyre. The surge consisting of 10,000 new UNIFIL troops was to be achieved in three waves.¹⁶ The first wave of some 3,500 troops would secure UNIFIL's rear and lines of communication, establish a presence in Tyre and support the handover from the IDF to the LAF. The second wave of another 3,500 troops would expand the UNIFIL footprint and support the LAF in achieving full operating capacity. The third wave of an additional 3,000 troops would enable UNIFIL, in addition to the above, to start verifying and monitoring the compliance of the parties with the provisions of Resolution 1701. Apart from the greater numbers, the new UNIFIL would cover a larger area of operations. For historical reasons, the area around the city of Tyre (a known Palestinian stronghold in 1978) was excluded from UNIFIL's original area of operations.¹⁷ In 2006, however, the area of operations was expanded on the basis of two arguments. On the one hand, Israel insisted on a UNIFIL buffer zone that would be wider than the range of Hezbollah's small rocket fire. On the other hand, the mandate to ensure that the UNIFIL area of operations would not be used for hostile activities required a clearly demarcated and controllable border. The valley cut out by the Litani river provided just such a natural topographical border, with only a limited number of crossing points that needed to be monitored.

Once the new UNIFIL would be operational, its mission would be twofold: (i) to assist the Government of Lebanon, and the LAF in particular, in exercising sovereignty over the entire Lebanese territory and securing its borders, and (ii) to ensure that its area of operations is not utilised for hostile activities of any kind. As such, UNIFIL can contribute to the conditions under which Israeli-Lebanese differences can be resolved through other means. The absence of Lebanese state sovereignty in the south was seen as the key factor in triggering conflict in the past. "Our mission", one general explained, "is thus very simple: it is to keep armed elements out of the area of operations."

In order to accomplish this mission, the enhanced UNIFIL would be active along five lines of operation. Apart from sustaining its own operations, supporting the

16. As outlined in the *Report of the Secretary-General on the implementation of resolution 1701 (2006)*, New York, United Nations Security Council, 18 August 2006, S/2006/670.

17. See Hillen, *op. cit.*, pp. 130-131.

LAF and stabilising the area through demining and reconstruction activities, its main military role would be to contain the former conflict parties by means of a show of presence. On the Lebanese side, the conflict parties were grouped together under the catch-all formula of ‘armed elements’ (AE), i.e. any group in possession of arms other than the LAF. This category included Palestinian militants as well as Hezbollah and other Lebanese armed groups. The strategic end-state would consist of the full restoration of the sovereign authority of the Lebanese government. A crude outline of UNIFIL’s operational design would then come to look as follows:¹⁸

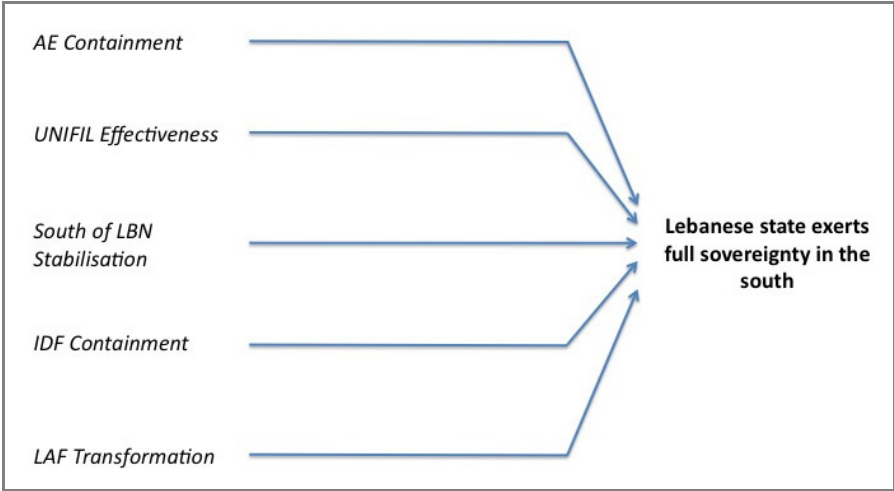


Figure 1: UNIFIL Lines of Operation

The operation was divided into five consecutive phases, each theoretically involving a review of the concept of operations and the accompanying force requirements. The first phase – cessation of hostilities – incorporated the transition to the enhanced UNIFIL. The second phase – IDF disengagement – involved the handover to the LAF. This also led to the force requirements being raised from 12,300 to 14,300 and a shift from engineering units to infantry units for patrolling. The third phase – transition and assistance to the LAF – implied that the LAF would now take the lead in maintaining control over the area. Phase four – stabilisation – would follow upon a more formal ceasefire agreement. This would allow for a reduction of force protection units and thus free up personnel for confidence-building patrolling etc. Phase five would consist of UNIFIL’s drawdown and withdrawal. One must keep in mind that these phases overlap. They merely describe the broad outline of UNIFIL’s functional evolu-

18. It is noteworthy that this level of conceptual clarity was only achieved as the operation got underway and was planned over and over again. In the summer of 2006, no operational design scheme was available.

tion over time: from build-up to gradual handover to the LAF and withdrawal. The operational phasing attempts to sketch greater conceptual clarity in this process and offers an opportunity to regularly review UNIFIL's role and posture. At the moment of writing, UNIFIL was in phase three and preparing for phase four. The Lebanese elections held on 7 June 2009 constituted one turning point in the switch from phase three to phase four; the debate over Lebanon's National Defence Strategy – and the question of Hezbollah's armed status – is another critical factor in this equation.

On the operational level, military planning efforts concentrated around three clusters. First of all, all planning documents need to be continuously reviewed and brought up-to-date. The original, phase one CONOPS was complemented by the UNIFIL enhancement operation plan, which was in turn translated into an operations order and complementary fragmentary orders. With each successive phase, and keeping into account changing circumstances on the ground, this body of documents needs to be rewritten at all levels. The second cluster of UNIFIL operational planning efforts is that of contingency planning. This is done in order to be ready to face a sudden deterioration of the security environment. Such envisaged contingencies ranged from the occurrence of a hostile act to the resumption of full scale hostilities between Hezbollah and the IDF or even the implications an Israeli strike on Iran would have on the situation in Lebanon. The planning for worst-case scenarios is one of the domains in which there was, at the request of the Force Commander, close cooperation between the planners in the field and the planners in the SMC. Because of the importance of this contingency planning, the planning team in the UNIFIL headquarters was also responsible for training efforts. All the exercises conducted by UNIFIL units could thus be organised in preparation of future contingencies. The third task of UNIFIL operational planners is to support the Force Commander and his political team. When more strategic work undertaken by the Force Commander, most notably in the tripartite framework that UNIFIL hosts for IDF-LAF dialogue, leads to newly agreed roles for UNIFIL, these need to be translated into plans as well. A good example is the project for visibly marking the Blue Line in order to minimize confusion over border crossing incidents. In the course of 2008, in order to ensure that the political work and military planning is coordinated at the different levels, a contact group was established within the UNIFIL headquarters.